

COVER TO COVER

2 Kings & THE PROPHETS BEFORE THE ASSYRIAN CAPTIVITY

Teaching Notes

(Northern Kingdom of Israel)

These prophets ministered while Israel still existed as a nation. Their primary message was:

"Repent or God will use Assyria to judge you."

Elijah (c. 870–850 BC)

- Ministered during the reign of Ahab and Jezebel.
- Did not write a prophetic book.
- Called Israel back to covenant faithfulness.
- Famous for Mount Carmel.
- **Before the Assyrian captivity.**

Elijah: God's Prophet During the Reign of Ahab and Jezebel

One of the most fascinating things research brings out is that Elijah appears in Scripture almost without introduction. Unlike Samuel, Isaiah, or Jeremiah, we are given no genealogy, no call narrative, and almost no background.

Suddenly, in **1 Kings 17:1**, a rugged prophet from Gilead walks into the palace of Israel's most wicked king and delivers one of the boldest prophecies in Scripture.

This abrupt appearance is intentional. Elijah's importance is not found in his pedigree but in his message. His life demonstrates that **God raises up exactly the right messenger at exactly the right time when His covenant is under attack.**

The Darkest Spiritual Period in Israel

Elijah ministered during the reign of **King Ahab**, who ruled the Northern Kingdom (Israel) approximately **22 years (about 874–853 BC)**. Although previous kings had worshiped the golden calves established by Jeroboam, Ahab crossed an entirely new line.

His marriage to **Jezebel**, the Phoenician princess from Sidon, completely changed Israel's spiritual landscape.

Research shows Jezebel did not simply bring another religion into Israel—she intended to **replace the worship of Yahweh with the worship of Baal and Asherah**. She imported hundreds of pagan prophets, built temples for Baal, financed them from the royal treasury, and systematically murdered the prophets of the Lord. Obadiah, a faithful servant in Ahab's palace, hid one hundred prophets in caves simply to keep them alive (1 Kings 18:4).

This was not merely political compromise; it was an assault on God's covenant with Israel. Kings is not simply recording history—it is showing what happens when God's covenant people abandon Him for the gods of the nations.

How Long Did Elijah Minister During Ahab's Reign?

Elijah's prophetic ministry overlaps much of Ahab's reign.

The Bible does not specify the exact number of years Elijah ministered to Ahab, but his recorded ministry spans roughly **nine to twelve years** during the latter portion of Ahab's rule. His public ministry begins with the announcement of the drought (1 Kings 17) and continues through the events surrounding Naboth's vineyard and Ahab's death (1 Kings 21–22).

The most significant period was the **three-and-a-half-year drought**, which James 5:17 confirms lasted **three years and six months**. During much of that time Elijah remained hidden by God's command—first at the Brook Cherith and later in Zarephath—before returning to confront Ahab publicly.

Why Elijah Declared the Drought

The drought was not simply punishment—it was a direct challenge to Baal.

Baal was believed throughout Canaan to be:

- god of rain
- god of storms
- god of lightning
- god of fertility

- god who made crops grow

If Baal controlled the weather, then Elijah's prophecy struck directly at Baal's supposed power.

When Elijah declared,

"There shall be neither dew nor rain except at my word,"

he was essentially saying:

"The God of Israel—not Baal—controls the heavens."

For three and a half years God shut heaven itself. Every dry riverbed, every dead crop, every starving animal became a testimony that Baal had absolutely no power.

The drought fulfilled the covenant warnings already given in Deuteronomy. Israel's suffering was not because God had abandoned His people but because He was calling them back to covenant faithfulness.

Elijah's Message to Ahab

When Elijah finally stood before Ahab again after years of drought, Ahab greeted him with accusation:

"Is that you, O troubler of Israel?"

Elijah's answer is one of the boldest prophetic rebukes in Scripture:

"I have not troubled Israel, but you and your father's house have, because you have forsaken the commandments of the Lord and followed the Baals."

Notice Elijah never blamed circumstances.

He blamed leadership.

Research shows Elijah understood that national spiritual decline begins when leaders abandon God's Word. The drought was not Israel's problem—it was the symptom. The real disease was covenant rebellion.

Mount Carmel: The Greatest Showdown

Why Mount Carmel?

Mount Carmel was not a random location.

Mount Carmel overlooked the Mediterranean Sea and was regarded as one of the most fertile, beautiful places in Israel.

More importantly, it was considered **sacred ground for Baal worship**.

If Baal truly ruled storms and lightning, then there could be no better place to prove it than on Baal's own "home field." ([Torah Class](#))

Elijah's Challenge

Elijah assembled:

- all Israel
- King Ahab
- 450 prophets of Baal
- (and, according to the text, 400 prophets of Asherah who were associated with Jezebel's court)

Then he asked one of the greatest questions in Scripture:

"How long will you limp between two opinions? If the Lord is God, follow Him. But if Baal, then follow him."

Research shows the Hebrew picture is of someone **hobbling between two paths**, trying to belong to both. Israel wanted Yahweh's blessings while also trusting Baal for prosperity and rain. Elijah declared that covenant faithfulness demanded an undivided heart.

The Contest

Two altars were prepared.

Two sacrifices were laid upon them.

No fire was allowed.

The god who answered by fire would be proven to be the true God.

For hours the prophets of Baal cried, danced, shouted, and cut themselves.

Nothing happened.

Elijah even mocked them:

- Maybe your god is sleeping.

- Maybe he's traveling.
- Maybe he's busy.

The irony is striking: the so-called storm god could not send even a single spark.

Elijah Repairs the Altar

One of the most beautiful moments comes before Elijah even prays.

He first **repairs the broken altar of the Lord** using **twelve stones**, representing all twelve tribes of Israel.

Although the nation was politically divided into north and south, God still viewed Israel as one covenant people. The repaired altar symbolized God's continuing covenant with the whole nation.

Then Elijah did something astonishing.

He had water poured over the sacrifice.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

Everything became soaked.

The trench filled with water.

Humanly speaking, the miracle became impossible.

Fire from Heaven

Elijah prayed one short prayer.

No screaming.

No dancing.

No manipulation.

Simply faith.

Immediately fire fell from heaven.

The fire consumed:

- the sacrifice
- the wood
- the stones
- the dust
- even the water in the trench

This was no ordinary fire.

It demonstrated that Yahweh alone commands heaven, lightning, rain, and judgment.

Israel's Response

The people immediately fell on their faces crying,

"The LORD, He is God! The LORD, He is God!"

This confession marked a national acknowledgment—at least for that moment—that Baal was powerless and Yahweh alone is the covenant God of Israel. ([Bible Gateway](#))

The Rain Returns

Only after Israel publicly acknowledged the Lord did Elijah go to the top of Carmel to pray for rain.

His servant looked toward the Mediterranean seven times.

On the seventh trip he saw:

"A little cloud like a man's hand."

Soon the heavens opened.

The rain returned.

This sequence is deeply theological: **repentance preceded restoration**. God first reclaimed Israel's allegiance before restoring the blessing of rain promised in His covenant.

Key Teaching Principles

Elijah's ministry reveals several enduring truths:

- **God often raises one courageous, obedient voice to confront widespread compromise.**
- **The drought was both judgment and mercy—it exposed the emptiness of false gods and called Israel back to covenant faithfulness.**
- **Mount Carmel was a confrontation between the God of the covenant and the gods of human invention, not merely a contest of miracles.**
- **Repairing the altar came before calling down the fire, illustrating that restored worship precedes spiritual renewal.**
- **Repentance came before rain, showing that God desires transformed hearts even more than restored circumstances.**

From beginning to end, Elijah's ministry proclaimed one central message: **Yahweh alone is sovereign over creation, faithful to His covenant, and worthy of Israel's undivided worship.**

Elisha (c. 850–800 BC)

- Did not write a prophetic book.
- Performed many miracles.
- Ministered to the northern kingdom before its fall.
- **Before the Assyrian captivity.**

Elisha: The Prophet of Restoration and Double Portion

Research shows that if Elijah is remembered as the prophet of **fire, confrontation, and covenant**, then Elisha is remembered as the prophet of **mercy, restoration, and God's continual presence among His people**. Although Elijah's ministry was dramatic and confrontational, Elisha's ministry demonstrated that after God judges, He delights in restoring His people. Elijah confronted kings; Elisha spent much of his ministry transforming ordinary lives while still speaking truth to rulers.

One of the most remarkable facts is that **Elisha performed nearly twice as many recorded miracles as Elijah**, beautifully illustrating the "double portion" he requested. The double portion was never about becoming more powerful than Elijah. It was about receiving the inheritance of a spiritual firstborn son so the prophetic ministry would continue uninterrupted.

The Calling of Elisha

Elisha first appears in **1 Kings 19**, immediately after Elijah's encounter with God at Mount Horeb.

God instructed Elijah to do three things:

- Anoint Hazael as king over Syria.
- Anoint Jehu as king over Israel.
- Call Elisha to become his successor.

When Elijah found Elisha, he was plowing with **twelve yoke of oxen**, personally driving the twelfth pair.

This detail tells us much about Elisha's background. Owning twelve yoke of oxen meant Elisha's family was prosperous. He was not a poor farmer struggling to survive. He was leaving security, wealth, inheritance, and social standing to follow God's call.

Elijah threw his mantle over Elisha—a symbolic act representing the transfer of prophetic authority.

Elisha immediately understood.

He returned home.

Killed the oxen.

Burned the wooden yokes as fuel.

Fed the people.

Then followed Elijah.

Research shows this was a deliberate act of finality. Elisha literally destroyed the tools of his former occupation. There would be no returning to his old life.

Learning Before Leading

Unlike many prophets who immediately began preaching, Elisha spent years serving Elijah.

The Bible repeatedly describes him as:

"the one who poured water on Elijah's hands."

That statement is profound.

Before Elisha ever carried God's mantle publicly, he carried water privately.

God's Kingdom values **faithfulness before prominence**. Elisha learned humility, observation, obedience, and dependence long before receiving public authority.

The Double Portion

As Elijah's earthly ministry came to an end, he asked Elisha:

"What shall I do for you before I am taken from you?"

Elisha answered:

"Please let a double portion of your spirit be upon me."

Many misunderstand this request.

Research shows Elisha was not asking for twice the Holy Spirit or twice Elijah's supernatural power.

In Israel's inheritance laws, the **firstborn son received a double portion** of the father's inheritance (Deuteronomy 21:17).

Elisha was asking to become Elijah's recognized spiritual heir.

This request demonstrated relationship, not ambition. Elisha desired the responsibility of carrying on God's prophetic ministry after Elijah's departure.

Elijah Taken to Heaven

The final journey of Elijah and Elisha is filled with symbolism.

They traveled together through:

- Gilgal
- Bethel
- Jericho
- The Jordan River

At every stop, Elijah invited Elisha to remain behind.

Each time Elisha answered:

"As the LORD lives, and as you yourself live, I will not leave you."

Research suggests these locations represented places deeply connected to Israel's covenant history. Elisha's unwavering commitment showed that spiritual inheritance belongs to those who remain faithful through every stage of testing.

When Elijah struck the Jordan with his mantle, the waters parted.

Both crossed on dry ground.

Soon afterward, a whirlwind appeared.

Horses and chariots of fire separated the two men.

Elijah was taken alive into heaven.

His mantle fell to Elisha.

The first miracle Elisha performed was striking the Jordan River with that mantle.

The waters parted again.

Immediately the sons of the prophets declared:

"The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha."

How Long Did Elisha Minister?

Research places Elisha's ministry at approximately **50 to 60 years**, making it one of the longest prophetic ministries recorded in Scripture.

He ministered during the reigns of several northern kings:

- **Jehoram (Joram)**
- **Jehu**
- **Jehoahaz**
- **Joash (Jehoash)**

Unlike Elijah, whose ministry centered primarily during Ahab's reign, Elisha's ministry stretched across multiple generations. This longevity highlights God's enduring faithfulness. Kings rose and fell, dynasties changed, but God's prophetic word remained constant.

A Prophet to Kings—and to Ordinary People

One of the striking differences between Elijah and Elisha is the scope of their ministries.

Elijah often confronted kings directly.

Elisha certainly advised kings, but much of his ministry focused on everyday people.

Research shows many of Elisha's miracles met ordinary needs:

- Purifying poisoned water at Jericho.
- Multiplying a widow's oil to save her sons from slavery.
- Raising the Shunammite woman's son.
- Healing poisoned stew.
- Feeding one hundred men with a small amount of food.
- Making an iron axe head float.
- Healing Naaman the Syrian of leprosy.

These miracles reveal God's concern for every aspect of life—not only national crises but also family, finances, health, provision, and hope. The covenant God is present in both the palace and the home.

The Healing of Naaman

Perhaps Elisha's most famous miracle involved **Naaman**, commander of the Syrian army.

Naaman expected dramatic ceremony.

Instead Elisha never even came outside.

He simply instructed Naaman to wash seven times in the Jordan River.

Naaman became angry because the Jordan seemed insignificant compared to Syria's rivers.

Research shows this was God's lesson in humility.

Healing did not come through impressive rituals.

It came through simple obedience.

God's power is never manipulated by human expectations. The issue was not the Jordan River—it was Naaman's heart. Only after humbling himself did he experience complete healing.

The Invisible Army

One of the greatest moments in Elisha's ministry occurred when the Syrian army surrounded the city of Dothan.

His servant panicked.

Elisha calmly prayed:

"Lord, open his eyes."

Suddenly the servant saw the mountain filled with horses and chariots of fire surrounding Elisha.

Research shows this is one of Scripture's clearest pictures of the unseen spiritual realm. God's protection is frequently present even when it is invisible. Faith is learning to trust what God has already provided, even when natural sight cannot perceive it.

Even His Death Testified of God's Power

Elisha eventually died and was buried.

Yet Scripture records one final miracle.

During a hurried burial, some Israelites threw a dead man into Elisha's tomb.

When the man's body touched Elisha's bones,

he immediately came back to life.

Research shows this miracle does not teach that bones possess magical power. Rather, it underscores that God's life-giving power continued to validate His prophet even after death. Elisha's ministry ended as it began—with God demonstrating that His power is not limited by human weakness or mortality.

Elijah and Elisha Compared

Research highlights a beautiful progression between these two prophets:

Elijah	Elisha
Prophet of confrontation	Prophet of restoration
Called down fire	Brought healing and life
Announced drought	Brought provision during famine
Challenged Baal publicly	Demonstrated God's compassion daily
Shorter public ministry	Long ministry across several kings
Confronted apostasy	Rebuilt faith through miracles
Ascended alive into heaven	Left a legacy that testified even after death

Together these ministries reveal two complementary aspects of God's character. Elijah shows God's holiness confronting sin; Elisha shows God's mercy restoring people to covenant life. Judgment and grace are not opposites—they are both expressions of God's covenant love.

Key Teaching Principles

Elisha's ministry offers enduring lessons for believers:

- **God often prepares His greatest servants through years of quiet, faithful service before public ministry.**
- **The "double portion" was a request for spiritual inheritance and responsibility, not personal greatness.**
- **God's miracles frequently meet ordinary needs, revealing His care for every area of life.**
- **Humble obedience, not impressive performance, is the pathway to experiencing God's power.**
- **The unseen resources of heaven are greater than the visible threats on earth.**
- **Faithfulness across decades can impact multiple generations, outlasting the rise and fall of earthly leaders.**

Taken together, Elijah and Elisha form a powerful theological portrait. Elijah called Israel back to the Lord by exposing the emptiness of idolatry. Elisha then demonstrated what life under God's covenant looks like: a life marked by restoration, provision, healing, compassion, and the continual presence of the living God.

Jonah (c. 780 BC)

- Sent to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria.
- Warned Israel indirectly by showing that even Israel's future enemy could repent.
- Written **before** Israel fell.

THE BOOK:

Jonah means Dove. His hometown, according to 2 Kings 14:25, was GATH – HEPHER, a village just 3 miles from Nazareth, the hometown of Jesus.

He was a good example of God working through a man who was like most of us... He wanted his own way, he was disobedient, he pouted... Etc.

The book of Jonah brings to us one of the most striking revelations of God.

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:

Arise—Go—Preach —1:2 and 3:2

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK

Jonah Flees — Chapter 1

Jonah Prays — Chapter 2

Jonah Preaches — Chapter 3

Jonah Learns — Chapter 4

Jonah: The Prophet Who Ran from God's Mercy

Research shows that the book of Jonah is often remembered simply as the story of a man swallowed by a great fish. The book is far more than a miracle story. It is a profound revelation of **God's sovereignty over the nations, His compassion for the Gentiles, and His desire to transform the heart of His own prophet.** The greatest miracle in Jonah is not the fish—it is God's relentless pursuit of both a rebellious city and a reluctant prophet.

Unlike Elijah and Elisha, whose ministries were primarily directed toward Israel, Jonah was sent outside Israel's borders. His assignment foreshadowed God's redemptive plan for all nations, reminding Israel that the covenant blessings they had received were ultimately intended to reveal the true God to the world.

Jonah's Historical Setting

Jonah lived during the reign of **Jeroboam II**, king of the Northern Kingdom of Israel, approximately **793–753 BC**. We first meet him in **2 Kings 14:25**, where he prophesied that Jeroboam II would restore Israel's borders.

This is significant.

Research shows that Jeroboam II was an **evil king**, continuing the idolatrous practices established by Jeroboam I. Yet during his reign Israel experienced remarkable military victories and economic prosperity.

This prosperity was not God's approval of Israel's spiritual condition. Instead, it demonstrated God's mercy. According to **2 Kings 14:26–27**, the Lord saw Israel's suffering and graciously delayed judgment, giving His people additional time to repent. Jonah initially delivered a message of national blessing before later receiving his difficult assignment to Nineveh.

Who Were the Ninevites?

Modern readers of this story often underestimate how shocking God's command would have been.

Nineveh was the capital of the **Assyrian Empire**.

The Assyrians were infamous throughout the ancient world for their brutality.

Historical records describe them:

- Skinning prisoners alive.
- Impaling captives on stakes.
- Decapitating entire populations.
- Piling heads outside conquered cities.
- Deporting survivors into exile.
- Using terror as a military strategy.

Assyria would eventually become the instrument God used to destroy the Northern Kingdom of Israel in **722 BC**.

From Jonah's perspective, these were not merely foreign people.

They were Israel's future enemy.

Jonah did not fear failure—he feared success. He knew God's character. If Nineveh repented, God might forgive them. Jonah wanted justice for Israel's enemies, while God desired repentance.

Why Jonah Ran

God commanded Jonah:

"Arise, go to Nineveh, that great city, and cry against it."

Instead, Jonah boarded a ship heading toward **Tarshish**, located in the opposite direction.

Research shows Tarshish represented the far western edge of the known world, while Nineveh lay to the northeast. Jonah intentionally traveled as far away from God's assignment as possible.

Jonah was not trying to escape God's presence because he believed that was possible. Rather, he attempted to avoid God's prophetic commission. In the ancient world, prophets were often associated with particular territories. Jonah hoped that by leaving the land of Israel he might avoid carrying out the mission God had entrusted to him.

The Storm at Sea

The Lord sent a violent storm upon the sea.

The experienced sailors became terrified.

Ironically, the pagan sailors prayed while God's prophet slept below deck.

Research shows the sailors displayed increasing reverence for the Lord throughout the story. After casting lots and discovering Jonah was responsible, they hesitated to throw him overboard because they did not want innocent blood on their hands.

Only after every other option failed did they cast Jonah into the sea.

Immediately the storm ceased.

The sailors then worshiped the Lord and offered sacrifices.

Look at this remarkable irony: before Jonah ever reached Nineveh, his disobedience had already become the means through which Gentiles began honoring the God of Israel. God's purposes continued even through Jonah's rebellion.

The Great Fish

God appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah. It was actually a “prepared fish” that was an act of preservation, not punishment.

Research shows Scripture never identifies the creature as a whale. The emphasis is not on the species but on God's sovereign appointment. The same God who appointed the storm also appointed the fish, later appointing a plant, a worm, and an east wind. Throughout the book, creation responds instantly to God's commands, while His prophet repeatedly resists.

Inside the fish Jonah remained **three days and three nights**.

There he prayed one of the most beautiful prayers of repentance in Scripture. There is not one word of petition in Jonah's prayer. It is a prayer of Thanksgiving and praise and rededication ...

Jonah's prayer is filled with quotations and themes from the Psalms. Even while running from God, Jonah still knew God's Word. His knowledge, however, had not yet fully transformed his heart.

In verse 9... Jonah had a change of heart... He states I will pay that I have vowed.

John was then vomited out on dryland... Safe and sound.

PIC: THE FISH CONNECTION...Jonah

The primary deity worshiped in Nineveh, was Dagon, and was often depicted as a half-man, half-fish figure. He was associated as a fertility and agricultural god, particularly among the Philistines.

Dagon was depicted as a standing man with a fish head, symbolizing his dual nature.

Nineveh's Repentance

After Jonah was delivered, God gave him the same commission a second time.

This time Jonah obeyed.

His message was remarkably brief:

"Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown."

Research shows Jonah offered no invitation, no explanation, and no promise of mercy.

Yet something astonishing happened.

From the king to the common people, Nineveh believed God.

The king stepped down from his throne.

He removed his royal robes.

He covered himself with sackcloth.

He sat in ashes.

He even commanded fasting for both people and livestock as visible signs of national repentance.

This became one of the greatest recorded revivals in Scripture. The repentance of pagan Nineveh stands in sharp contrast to Israel's repeated refusal to respond to generations of prophetic warnings.

Jonah's Anger

The story reaches its surprising climax after Nineveh repents.

Jonah becomes angry.

He tells God exactly why he fled:

"I knew that You are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abundant in lovingkindness."

This is perhaps the greatest irony in the book.

Jonah was not upset because God judged Nineveh.

He was upset because God forgave them.

Research shows Jonah loved receiving God's mercy for Israel but struggled to celebrate God's mercy toward Israel's enemies.

Jonah's greatest problem was not outward disobedience but inward prejudice. His heart had become narrower than God's.

The Lesson of the Plant

Manah: (maw-naw) God appointed or prepared a:

Fish

Gord

Worm

And an east wind.

God caused a leafy plant to grow, providing Jonah with shade.

Jonah rejoiced.

The next day God appointed a worm.

The worm destroyed the plant.

Then God appointed a scorching east wind.

Jonah became miserable.

God asked:

"Should I not have compassion on Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left?"

The plant became an object lesson.

Jonah cared more about the comfort of a temporary plant than about the eternal destiny of an entire city.

The book ends without revealing Jonah's response.

Research suggests this open ending invites every reader to answer the question personally:

Will your heart rejoice in God's mercy for others, even those you consider undeserving?

Jonah and Assyria

An important historical perspective is that Nineveh's repentance did not permanently change Assyria.

Research shows that within a few generations, Assyria returned to its violent ways and eventually conquered the Northern Kingdom in **722 BC**, carrying Israel into exile.

This does not diminish Jonah's mission. God extended genuine mercy when there was genuine repentance. Later generations, however, chose rebellion again and eventually experienced judgment. God's mercy never cancels His justice; rather, it delays judgment to provide opportunity for repentance.

Jonah and Jesus

Jesus identified Jonah as a prophetic sign pointing to Himself.

Just as Jonah spent three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish before emerging alive, Jesus would spend three days in the tomb before His resurrection (Matthew 12:39–41).

Jesus also highlighted another contrast.

The people of Nineveh repented after hearing the message of one reluctant prophet.

Yet many in Jesus' own generation rejected One who was infinitely greater than Jonah.

Research shows Jonah's experience became both a historical event and a prophetic picture of the gospel itself: death, deliverance, repentance, and God's invitation of salvation to all peoples.

Jonah Compared with Elijah and Elisha

Elijah	Elisha	Jonah
Confronted Israel's idolatry	Restored Israel through miracles	Called a Gentile nation to repentance
Challenged kings	Served kings and ordinary people	Preached primarily to a foreign empire
Fire from heaven	Healing and restoration	Mercy extended to enemies
Opposed Baal worship	Demonstrated God's compassion	Revealed God's compassion for the nations
Called Israel back to covenant	Strengthened covenant faith	Foreshadowed God's global redemption

Together, these three prophets reveal the breadth of God's character. Elijah proclaims God's holiness, Elisha displays His restoring compassion, and Jonah unveils His heart for all nations. The God of Israel has always been the God of the whole world, and His covenant with Israel was intended to become a blessing to every nation (Genesis 12:3).

Key Teaching Principles

Jonah's life leaves several enduring lessons:

- **God's mercy extends beyond Israel to every nation that turns to Him in repentance.**
- **Running from God's assignment never frustrates God's purposes; He faithfully pursues both His servant and those He seeks to save.**
- **Outward obedience is incomplete without a heart that reflects God's compassion.**
- **God often uses unexpected people and circumstances to accomplish His redemptive plan.**
- **Repentance can delay judgment, but each generation must choose whether to remain faithful.**
- **The greatest challenge for God's people is not merely proclaiming His truth but sharing His heart for those who seem least deserving of grace.**

The story of Jonah ultimately asks every believer the same searching question that closes the book: **Will we rejoice when God shows mercy to those we struggle to love, or will we resist His compassion because it reaches beyond our own expectations?**

Amos (c. 760 BC)

- Preached primarily to the Northern Kingdom.
- Warned that injustice and idolatry would bring destruction.
- **Written about 35–40 years before Assyria conquered Israel.**

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:

Can two walk together, except they be agreed Amos 3:3

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK:

- 1) Judgement of Surrounding Nations — 1:1 — 2:3
- 2) Judgment of Judah and Israel — 2:4 — 6:14
- 3) Visions of the Future — Chapters 7-9

JUDGMENTS OF SURROUNDING NATIONS:

- Judgment against Syria for cruelty – 1: 3–5
- Judgment against PHILISTIA for selling Israelites into slavery in Edom– 1:6–8
- Judgment against PHOENICIA for breaking their covenant with Israel – 1:9–10
- Judgment against Edom for causing Israel to suffer– 1:11–12
- Judgment against AMMON for violence against Israel – 1: 13–15
- Judgment against Moab for injustice – 2:1–3

JUDGEMENT OF JUDAH AND ISRAEL:2:4–6:14

- Judgment against Judah for despising the law – 2:4–5
- Judgment against Israel for immorality – 2:6–16
- God's charge against the whole house of Israel – the 12 tribes – 3:1–6: 14

VISIONS OF THE FUTURE: CHAPTERS 7-9

- Visions of the grasshoppers – 7:1–3
- Visions of the fire – 7:4–6
- Visions of the plum line – 7:7–17
- Visions of basket of summer fruit – chapter 8
- Vision of the Lord at the altar – 9:1–10
- Future Kingdom and David's Tabernacle – 9: 11–15.

Amos: The Shepherd Who Confronted a Prosperous but Spiritually Corrupt Nation

Research shows that Amos was not a professional prophet, priest, or member of a prophetic school. He was a shepherd and a cultivator of sycamore-fig trees whom God unexpectedly called to deliver one of the strongest messages of justice and covenant accountability in the Old Testament.

Amos demonstrates God is not limited to religious institutions when choosing His messengers. When leaders become compromised, God often raises ordinary people who are wholly devoted to His Word.

Although Amos came from the Southern Kingdom of Judah, God sent him to preach primarily in the **Northern Kingdom of Israel**, making him one of the earliest writing prophets. His message came during a time of remarkable prosperity but deep spiritual decay. While the nation appeared successful on the outside, God saw a society built upon injustice, idolatry, and broken covenant.

The Historical Setting

Amos ministered during the reigns of:

- **Uzziah**, king of Judah (Southern Kingdom)
- **Jeroboam II**, king of Israel (Northern Kingdom)

His ministry is usually dated around **760–755 BC**, making him a contemporary of **Jonah**, with **Hosea** and **Isaiah beginning** their ministries shortly afterward.

Research shows Israel was enjoying one of its greatest periods of wealth since Solomon. Military victories had expanded the nation's borders. Trade flourished. The wealthy built luxurious homes, accumulated land, and lived comfortably.

Yet beneath the prosperity lay corruption.

This period illustrates one of Scripture's recurring warnings: **material blessing can become spiritually dangerous when people mistake prosperity for God's approval**. Israel assumed that because life was good, God must be pleased. Amos declared exactly the opposite.

A Shepherd Called by God

Amos introduces himself simply:

"I was among the shepherds of Tekoa."

Tekoa was a small town approximately ten miles south of Jerusalem.

Research shows the Hebrew word translated "shepherd" likely refers to someone who raised a special breed of sheep prized for their wool. Amos also cared for sycamore-fig trees, which required cutting or piercing the fruit so it would ripen properly.

Look at the symbolism here:

Before Amos ever diagnosed the spiritual sickness of a nation, he spent years caring for sheep and cultivating fruit.

God often prepares His servants through ordinary faithfulness before entrusting them with extraordinary assignments.

Amos himself later declared:

"I was neither a prophet nor the son of a prophet...but the LORD took me."

His authority rested entirely upon God's calling rather than religious credentials.

Why Amos Was Sent to Israel

God sent Amos north to preach primarily at **Bethel**, one of the two major centers of calf worship established centuries earlier by Jeroboam I.

Research shows Bethel had become both a political and religious capital for the Northern Kingdom.

Thousands faithfully attended religious festivals.

Sacrifices were continually offered.

Music filled the sanctuaries.

Yet God rejected their worship.

One of Amos's central themes:

God is never impressed by religious activity that is disconnected from covenant obedience.

Israel believed that frequent worship guaranteed God's favor.

God declared that He hated their festivals because their lives contradicted their worship.

The Roaring Lion

Amos opens his prophecy with unforgettable imagery:

"The LORD roars from Zion."

Research shows lions roar immediately before attacking.

This image communicates certainty.

God was no longer whispering warnings.

Judgment was approaching.

The roar announced that covenant violations had reached their limit.

The Lion was leaving His place to act.

Judgment Begins with the Nations

One of Amos's most remarkable literary features is how he begins.

Rather than immediately condemning Israel, Amos first pronounces judgment upon Israel's surrounding enemies:

- Damascus (Syria)
- Gaza (Philistia)
- Tyre
- Edom
- Ammon
- Moab

The Israelites likely applauded.

Then Amos turned toward Judah.

Finally...

He pointed directly at Israel.

Research shows this progression was intentional.

Amos skillfully drew his audience into agreement before revealing that the greatest guilt belonged to God's own covenant people.

Israel possessed greater revelation.

Therefore Israel bore greater responsibility.

Israel's Greatest Sins

Unlike many prophets who focused primarily on idolatry, Amos repeatedly addressed **social injustice**.

Research shows Israel's wealthy elite:

- Exploited the poor.
- Accepted bribes.
- Corrupted the courts.
- Stole land from vulnerable families.
- Sold people into slavery over insignificant debts.
- Lived in luxury while ignoring suffering.

Amos declared:

"They sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals."

God's concern for justice is woven throughout His covenant with Israel.

True worship cannot exist while people oppress those created in God's image.

One of Amos's greatest contributions is reminding believers that spiritual maturity includes both right worship and righteous treatment of others.

"Let Justice Roll Down Like Waters"

Perhaps Amos's most famous statement is:

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

Research shows this image contrasts Israel's temporary seasonal streams, which often dried up, with God's desire for continual justice.

Justice was never intended to appear only during religious festivals.

It should flow every day throughout society.

Righteousness is not merely personal morality.

Biblically, righteousness includes faithful covenant relationships with both God and people.

The Basket of Summer Fruit

One of Amos's final visions involves a basket of ripe summer fruit.

At first glance it seems pleasant.

Yet the Hebrew contains a wordplay.

The Hebrew word for **summer fruit (qayits)** sounds nearly identical to the word for **end (qets)**.

God was declaring:

"The fruit is ripe."

"The nation is ripe."

"The time has come."

Research shows this vision symbolized that Israel's opportunities for repentance were nearly exhausted.

Judgment had become inevitable because the people continually rejected God's repeated warnings.

The Plumb Line

One of Amos's most powerful visions is that of the **plumb line**.

God showed Amos a builder holding a plumb line against a wall.

A plumb line determines whether a structure remains perfectly vertical.

Research shows ancient builders used plumb lines because even slight deviations eventually weakened entire buildings.

God Himself is the standard.

Israel was not being compared to neighboring nations.

They were being measured against God's covenant.

The wall had become crooked.

It could no longer remain standing.

The plumb line reminds believers that God's Word—not culture—is the measure of spiritual integrity.

Amaziah Opposes Amos

Amos eventually encountered opposition from **Amaziah**, priest at Bethel.

Amaziah told Amos:

"Go back to Judah."

In other words,

"Take your message somewhere else."

Amos answered that he had never sought this ministry.

God had taken him from shepherding and sent him to speak.

Research shows this confrontation reveals the conflict between institutional religion and genuine prophetic truth.

False security often comes through religious systems that have drifted away from God's covenant.

The Coming Assyrian Judgment

Amos repeatedly warned that unless Israel repented,

God would raise a nation against them.

Although Assyria is not always named immediately, history confirms that within about **35–40 years**, Assyria invaded the Northern Kingdom.

In **722 BC**, Samaria fell.

Israel was carried into exile.

Everything Amos warned came to pass.

Research shows Amos's prophecies were fulfilled with remarkable accuracy.

The prosperous kingdom that believed itself untouchable disappeared.

Hope at the End

Although Amos is filled with judgment, it ends with hope.

God promises:

"I will restore the fallen booth (tabernacle) of David."

This prophecy reaches beyond the immediate restoration after exile.

The New Testament quotes this passage in **Acts 15**, where James explains that through Jesus the restoration of David's kingdom now includes Gentile believers.

Amos ends where all biblical prophecy ultimately ends—not with destruction but with redemption.

God judges in order to restore.

The covenant continues because of God's faithfulness, not Israel's perfection.

Amos Compared with Elijah, Elisha, and Jonah

Elijah	Elisha	Jonah	Amos
Confronted idolatry	Restored through miracles	Called Gentiles to repent	Confronted injustice and false worship
Prophet during Ahab	Prophet across several kings	Prophet to Nineveh	Prophet to prosperous Israel
Fire from heaven	Healing and provision	Mercy for enemies	Covenant accountability
Challenged Baal	Demonstrated compassion	Revealed God's mercy	Declared God's justice
Focused on covenant loyalty	Focused on restoration	Focused on God's compassion	Focused on righteousness and justice

Together these prophets reveal complementary dimensions of God's character. Elijah calls God's people away from false gods. Elisha reveals God's restoring compassion. Jonah demonstrates

God's mercy toward the nations. Amos insists that genuine covenant faith must be visible in justice, righteousness, and integrity.

Key Teaching Principles

Amos leaves believers with several enduring truths:

- **God often calls ordinary, faithful people to confront extraordinary spiritual compromise.**
- **Material prosperity is never proof of spiritual health or God's approval.**
- **True worship cannot be separated from justice, integrity, and compassion for others.**
- **God measures His people by the standard of His covenant, not by comparison with the surrounding culture.**
- **Repeated rejection of God's warnings eventually leads to judgment, but His purpose is always to call people back to Himself.**
- **Even in pronouncing judgment, God preserves hope by promising restoration through the Davidic King, fulfilled ultimately in Jesus Christ.**

Amos is not merely a book about social reform. It is a covenant lawsuit. God, the righteous Judge, presents His case against His covenant people, exposing where they have abandoned His ways. Yet the final note is one of hope: the God who measures His people with a plumb line is also the God who promises to rebuild what has fallen. Judgment is never His final word—**redemption is.**

Hosea (c. 755–715 BC)

- Ministered during Israel's final decades.
- His marriage illustrated Israel's spiritual adultery.
- Continued preaching almost until Samaria fell.
- **Written before and possibly during the final years leading up to the Assyrian conquest (722 BC).**

Hosea was a contemporary of Amos... Both prophesied to the northern kingdom of Israel. Hosea is often called “the prophet of Israel’s zero hour.”...

Israel had degenerated into such spiritual depravity that God’s judgment could no longer be delayed.

2 Kings 15–17 covers the period of Hosea and records the terrible sins of idol worship and unbridled sex in that time.

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:

Return to the Lord... Hosea6:1

The word return occurs 15 times in Hosea.

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK

Hosea—His marriage—compared to God and Israel —Chapters 1-3...and analogy.

Sin, judgement and ultimate blessing of Israel — chapters 4-14

Hosea: The Prophet Who Lived God's Broken Heart

Hosea's life was not merely the background to his message—it was his message.

More than any other prophet, Hosea was called to **live out** the relationship between God and Israel through his own marriage.

Hosea is one of the most emotionally moving books in Scripture because it reveals **the heart of God** rather than simply the judgment of God. Through Hosea's pain, God allows us to glimpse His own grief over Israel's spiritual adultery.

While Amos primarily exposed Israel's injustice, Hosea exposed **Israel's unfaithfulness**. Amos sounds like a prosecutor presenting evidence in court. Hosea sounds like a heartbroken husband pleading with the wife he still loves.

Hosea is not primarily about an unfaithful wife—it is about a faithful God.

The Historical Setting

Hosea ministered during one of the most unstable periods in Israel's history.

His ministry stretched approximately **40 to 50 years (around 755–710 BC)** during the reigns of:

Judah

- Uzziah

- Jotham
- Ahaz
- Hezekiah

Israel

- Jeroboam II

Research shows Hosea began prophesying near the end of Jeroboam II's prosperous reign and continued through Israel's rapid decline until shortly before the Assyrian conquest in **722 BC**.

Hosea watched the Northern Kingdom slowly collapse from within.

After Jeroboam II died:

- six kings ruled within about thirty years.
- four were assassinated.
- political chaos exploded.
- Assyria grew stronger.
- Israel continued refusing to repent.

The nation was falling apart politically because it had already fallen apart spiritually.

God's Shocking Command

The book begins with one of the most surprising commands in Scripture.

God told Hosea:

"Go, take yourself a wife of harlotry."

This command has generated much discussion.

Research shows several interpretations exist:

- Gomer was already living an immoral lifestyle.
- Gomer later became unfaithful after marriage.
- The wording may anticipate what she would become.

Regardless of which interpretation one adopts, the theological point remains the same:

Hosea's marriage became a living picture of God's covenant with Israel.

Just as Hosea genuinely loved Gomer despite her repeated betrayal, God genuinely loved Israel despite her continual spiritual adultery.

Gomer Represents Israel

Throughout Hosea,

Gomer repeatedly leaves her husband.

She pursues other lovers.

She believes they provide her:

- food
- clothing
- wine
- oil
- prosperity

Research shows this mirrors Israel's worship of Baal.

The Israelites believed Baal provided:

- rain
- crops
- fertility
- prosperity
- military success

Israel had not completely abandoned God.

Instead,

they attempted to worship both Yahweh and Baal simultaneously.

This mixture became spiritual adultery.

God desired covenant faithfulness,

not divided loyalty.

The Three Children

God instructed Hosea to give symbolic names to his children.

Each name became a prophecy. The children were named to symbolize judgment.

Jezreel—means God scatters.

Jezreel reminded Israel that God would soon judge the house of Jehu.

The valley of Jezreel had witnessed both Jehu's divinely authorized judgment and later generations' abuse of violence.

God declared that Israel's kingdom would soon end.

Lo-Ruhamah—means “not obtained mercy”

Meaning:

"No Mercy"

Research shows this signified that the Northern Kingdom had exhausted God's patience.

Judgment was approaching.

Yet even here God promised continued mercy toward Judah for a time.

Lo-Ammi—Means “Not my people”

Meaning:

"Not My People"

This may be the most devastating name of all.

It echoes the covenant formula:

"I will be your God,
and you shall be My people."

Now God declared:

"You are not My people."

This was covenant language.

Israel had so persistently broken the covenant that they were experiencing its legal consequences.

Yet God immediately followed with future promises of restoration.

Even covenant discipline was never God's final word.

Hosea Redeems Gomer

Perhaps the most beautiful scene occurs later in the book.

Gomer has become enslaved.

She had descended into poverty and humiliation because of her sinful choices.

God instructed Hosea:

"Go again.

Love a woman who is loved by another."

Hosea purchased his own wife back.

He redeemed her.

Not because she deserved it.

Because he loved her.

This is one of Scripture's clearest Old Testament pictures of redemption.

The offended husband becomes the redeemer.

This beautifully foreshadows Christ,

who purchases His unfaithful Bride with His own blood.

Hosea's patience, compassion and his final acts of redeeming, chastening and restoring Gomer are the same qualities God will, and does, have for sinning Israel

Israel's Greatest Sin

Hosea repeatedly returns to one issue:

Israel no longer knew God.

One of the book's most famous verses declares:

"My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge."

Research shows the Hebrew word "know" means far more than intellectual information.

It describes intimate covenant relationship.

Israel still possessed religious ceremonies.

They still offered sacrifices.

But they had lost genuine relationship with God.

Religion had replaced intimacy.

Knowledge about God had replaced knowing God.

"I Desire Mercy, Not Sacrifice"

God declares:

"For I desire mercy and not sacrifice,
and the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."

Jesus later quoted this verse twice.

Research shows Hosea reveals God's priorities.

Sacrifices were never intended to replace obedience.

Worship without covenant faithfulness was empty.

God's desire has always been relationship before ritual.

The Valley of Achor

One of Hosea's most beautiful promises involves the Valley of Achor.

The Valley of Achor was where Achan's sin brought judgment upon Israel in Joshua 7.

Its name means:

"Trouble."

Yet God promises:

"I will make the Valley of Trouble a door of hope."

Research shows this reveals God's redemptive character.

The very place associated with failure becomes the place where hope begins.

Only God can transform places of judgment into places of restoration.

"I Will Betroth You Forever"

One of Hosea's greatest themes is covenant renewal.

God promises:

"I will betroth you to Me forever."

Notice the progression.

He does not merely forgive.

He restores the marriage.

Research shows the language intentionally recalls Israel's original covenant at Mount Sinai.

God was promising a future relationship built upon:

- righteousness
- justice
- lovingkindness
- compassion
- faithfulness

This ultimately points toward the New Covenant established through Jesus Christ.

Assyria Is Coming

Throughout Hosea,

God repeatedly warns that Assyria is coming.

Israel sought political alliances with:

- Assyria
- Egypt

instead of trusting God.

Note the tragic irony.

The nation Israel trusted for protection became the nation that conquered them.

In **722 BC**,

Assyria destroyed Samaria.

The Northern Kingdom ceased to exist as an independent nation.

Everything Hosea warned became reality.

Hope Beyond Judgment

Like Amos,

Hosea refuses to end with destruction.

Instead,

God declares:

"How can I give you up, Ephraim?"

These may be among the most emotional words God speaks anywhere in Scripture.

God's justice required judgment.

His love longed for restoration.

Research shows Hosea reveals the tension within God's covenant dealings.

He disciplines because He loves.

He wounds in order to heal.

He scatters in order to gather again.

Hosea allows readers to hear God's broken heart more clearly than almost any other prophetic book.

Hosea Compared with Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, and Amos

Elijah	Elisha	Jonah	Amos	Hosea
Confronted idolatry	Restored through miracles	Called Gentiles to repent	Exposed injustice	Revealed God's broken heart
Prophet during Ahab	Prophet across several kings	Prophet to Nineveh	Prophet to prosperous Israel	Prophet during Israel's final decline
Fire from heaven	Healing and provision	Mercy to enemies	Justice for the oppressed	Covenant love despite betrayal
Challenged Baal	Demonstrated compassion	Revealed mercy	Declared righteousness	Lived redemption through marriage

Together these prophets paint a remarkable portrait of God. Elijah proclaims His holiness. Elisha displays His compassion. Jonah reveals His mercy for the nations. Amos demands justice and covenant faithfulness. Hosea unveils the tender, wounded heart of a God who continues to pursue His unfaithful people with steadfast love.

Key Teaching Principles

Hosea leaves believers with several timeless truths:

- **God desires covenant relationship, not merely religious activity.**
- **Spiritual compromise is portrayed in Scripture as adultery because God has entered into a covenant of faithful love with His people.**
- **God's discipline is an expression of His love, designed to bring His people back rather than simply punish them.**
- **Redemption means paying the price to restore what has been lost, beautifully foreshadowing Christ's work on the cross.**
- **The deepest knowledge of God is relational intimacy, not simply acquiring biblical information.**
- **God specializes in turning valleys of trouble into doors of hope and restoring broken covenant relationships.**

Hosea is one of the clearest Old Testament portraits of the gospel. The faithful husband pursues the unfaithful bride, pays the price to redeem her, and offers covenant restoration instead of rejection. In Hosea we see not only the tragedy of Israel's sin but also the astonishing depth of God's covenant love—a love ultimately fulfilled in Jesus Christ, the Bridegroom who gave Himself for His Bride.

The Big Picture

Together these five prophets reveal the complete heart of God.

- **Elijah** proclaimed God's holiness.
- **Elisha** demonstrated God's compassion.
- **Jonah** revealed God's mercy for all nations.
- **Amos** called God's people to justice and covenant faithfulness.
- **Hosea** unveiled God's relentless covenant love.

Although each prophet had a unique assignment, they all proclaimed the same essential message:

Return to the Lord while there is still time. God's judgment is real, but His desire has always been repentance, restoration, and redemption.